Glossary — Words We Use Precisely

This course brainwashes you into an ambitious, conversion-heavy mindset — and vocabulary is the delivery mechanism. These definitions are fixed. We will correct you in check-ins. Kindly. Every time.

The Core Five

Term	Definition	What it is NOT
VALIDATION	Somebody opens their wallet.	Interviews, likes, signups, compliments — that's all signal.
SIGNAL	Evidence below the wallet line (interviews, clicks, signups, waitlists). Earns you the right to run the next, more expensive test.	Proof. Signal never "validates" anything.
PROTOTYPE	A very quickly built slice of the product that your user base is **willing to pay money for**.	A mockup, a Figma flow, a demo video. Those are props — useful for collecting signal, but nobody pays for a prop.
CUSTOMER	A user who pays.	A user. A user who doesn't pay is a **fan**. Fans are lovely and pay no rent.
KILL	An evidence-based decision to stop — announced, documented, celebrated.	Failure. In this course a rigorous kill is a gradeable win (see the rubric).

The Supporting Cast

Term	Definition
User	Someone who actually uses the product. Not someone who said they would.
Pilot	A paid engagement with fixed scope, fixed duration (2–4 weeks), agreed success criteria, and a conversion path to recurring revenue. An unpaid pilot is a favor.
MVP	The smallest thing that can trigger validation (a wallet opening). If it can't be paid for, it's not viable — it's minimal and useless.
Concierge	Delivering the outcome as a manual service, zero product. Fully legitimate revenue; the highest-signal prototype there is.
Traction	Customers paying repeatedly — same offer, more than once, without custom scope. One favor-sale is an anecdote.
Revenue quality	The ladder: custom project < paid pilot < repeatable offer < recurring subscription. The leaderboard ranks quality, not just quantity.
Hair-on-fire segment	The people who have the problem worst: frequency × intensity × current spend — and would text you at 2am about it.
Budget authority	The person who can say yes to money. The pain-haver and the budget-holder are often different people; your Pain Map carries both.
Vision / Moonshot	The mountain: market ceiling, why it matters, who joins you. Picks which wedges are worth driving.
Wedge	The first foothold: a problem so specific you can win it this semester. Where the vision touches the ground.
Threshold	A pass/fail number written and dated BEFORE the test (Kill Criteria Log). Anything committed after seeing data is commentary, not a threshold.
Monkey first	Test the hardest, most uncertain assumption first — never the pedestal that feels like progress.
GPK	Go / Pivot / Kill — decided on pre-committed criteria, scored on artifacts (framework 03).

Say This, Not That

× Don't say	✓ Say
"We validated the problem with 10 interviews."	"We collected strong interview signal. Validation starts when a wallet opens."
"We have 50 users!"	"We have 50 users and 0 customers — conversion is this week's job."
"Our prototype is almost ready to show."	"Our prototype is live; 3 strangers used it; 1 paid."
"The pilot went great, they loved it."	"The pilot converted at €400/month starting March."
"We failed — the idea didn't work."	"We killed it on evidence: threshold was 10%, we measured 2%. Here's the autopsy and the next test."
"We're pre-revenue."	Never say this. You're "three asks away from revenue" — and you know the three names.

Used in every check-in from Module 00 onward. If a slide, workshop, or homework uses these words loosely, flag it — the language IS the mindset.